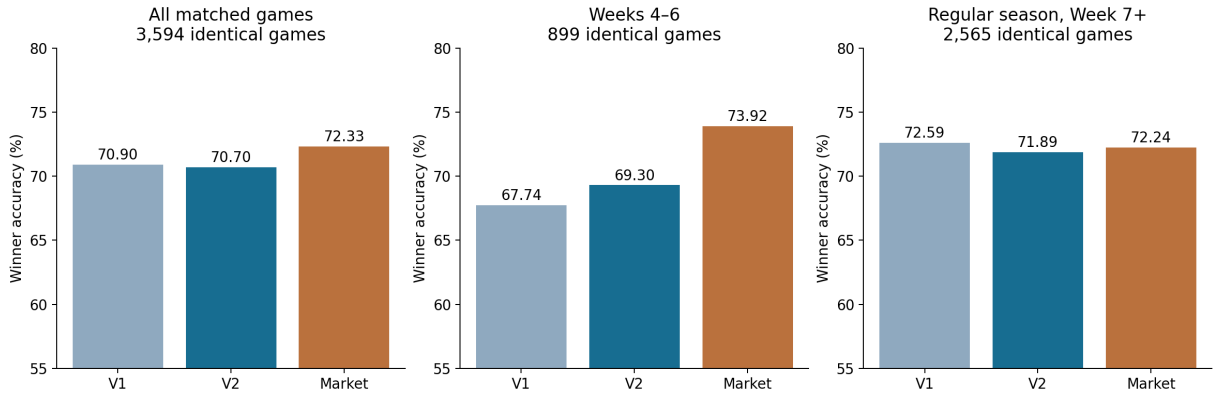
Four improvements to the season-only neural ranker

Research date 2026-10-13 (America/Denver). See REPORT.html for every export and source.

The study implements an early-season expert, availability ingestion and production-based adjustments, richer game-context features, and a stricter chronological/quote-time evaluation. Historical games teach shared weights; forecast inputs remain current-season only. Identities resolve joins and are never embeddings.

Historical development results

Period	Games	V1	V2	Change
all	3603	70.86%	70.69%	-0.17 points
weeks 4 6	900	67.67%	69.22%	+1.56 points
either team at most five games	1379	68.67%	69.83%	+1.16 points
regular week 7 onward	2569	72.60%	71.90%	-0.70 points
postseason	134	58.96%	57.46%	-1.49 points



These seasons have been inspected. They remain retrospective development evidence. Lower log loss means better probabilities; all exact scores and phase cohorts are in the HTML and CSVs.

Archived market comparison

Market	Games	V2	Market	Difference
spread market	3594	70.70%	72.33%	-1.63 points
moneyline market	3025	69.95%	71.14%	-1.19 points

The old archive has no capture times. Those results do not establish equal-information-time trading performance. Season-block intervals have only five or six blocks.

Timestamp-matched 2026 replay

Market	Max age	N	V1	V2	Market
moneyline	24 hours	130	70.77%	70.00%	70.00%
spread	24 hours	129	71.32%	70.54%	69.77%
moneyline	72 hours	131	70.99%	70.23%	70.23%
spread	72 hours	129	71.32%	70.54%	69.77%

Quotes must be observed, captured, and available at or before the model cutoff. Sides must match the exact capture and sportsbook. One sportsbook gets one vote across vendors. Live/post-kickoff, inferred, stale, ambiguous, and invalid quotes are excluded. This is a small public 2026 replay, not an untouched prospective trial or a long historical closing-line archive.

All variants on the primary moneyline cohort

Model	N	Accuracy	Brier	Log loss
v1_recommended	130	70.77%	0.1961	0.5786
v2_recommended	130	70.00%	0.1939	0.5728
v2_rich	130	73.08%	0.1971	0.5803
v2_context	130	70.00%	0.1939	0.5728
v2_full	130	68.46%	0.2016	0.5890
v2_graph_context	130	66.15%	0.2111	0.6162
moneyline_market	130	70.00%	0.1920	0.5618

The rich-input specialist has a higher point hit rate than the market here, but worse probability scores. Exact paired p = 0.572. The small replay does not establish a reliable market edge or justify changing the registered selection after outcomes.

Models and chronological selection

rich (64 features): Prior score and play summaries; new specialist training. 2020–2025 accuracy 70.91%; log loss 0.5621.

context (112 features): Adds 40 situation/drive ratings and eight evidence/uncertainty signals. 2020–2025 accuracy 70.69%; log loss 0.5673.

full (152 features): Adds 16 player-production/continuity signals and 24 ordered game-history signals. 2020–2025 accuracy 69.28%; log loss 0.5765.

graph_context (240 features): Combines the previous opponent graph with every new signal. 2020–2025 accuracy 68.97%; log loss 0.6212.

Folds: 2006–2013 trains 2014–2015 validation; 2006–2015 trains 2016–2017; 2006–2017 trains 2018–2019. All annual weights use earlier seasons. There are 32 configurations, three folds, two experts, and three seeds: 576 valid final-search fits. Validation reuse can overfit model selection.

Early-season expert

The gate is sigmoid((5 − smaller team game count)/1.5). Historical examples with limited evidence receive larger weight in the early expert. Probability blends the global and early experts according to the gate. Every neutral empty snapshot starts at .500.

Context and sequences

Opponent-adjusted situation and drive ratings cover down/distance, red-zone and backed-up offense, close-score states, drive finishing, turnovers, and pace. Evidence features measure sample size, schedule connectivity, uncertainty, and recency. Full variants add current-season player continuity and three ordered games. Ordered features are not described as a recurrent network.

Availability: implemented with limited public coverage

The sourced pilot contains 20 events from 10 articles and 24 game comparisons. It changed 9 probabilities. Winner accuracy was 62.50% before and 62.50% after adjustment. This hand-selected pilot tests integration and cannot estimate population benefit.

Every report needs season, team/player join, publication and availability times, effective interval, target game when applicable, status, and provenance. Day-only sources become available after the end of their publication day. Stale prior-year injury notes are rejected. Unreported players remain unknown, ambiguous joins are rejected, and unsupported positions receive no invented impact.

Adjustments use current-season production and replacement performance. Players already absent from recent usage receive no repeated penalty. Uncertain status probabilities are nominal scenario assumptions with available/out endpoints. Availability works in the full model variants; the selected context model excludes these player inputs because the older folds did not support the larger variants.

Prospective registration

Issued at 2026-10-13T20:32:02.767092-06:00. The registry freezes 789 genuinely future fixtures, weights, a portable feature snapshot, current Week 6 statistics, known reports, timely prices, and grading rules. It refuses overwrite. The grader rejects pre-issuance games and premature or unsourced scores. No prospective result exists yet.

A benchmark-only addendum recorded before registered games begin normalizes sportsbook case aliases and excludes unverifiable raw-file references. It preserves original forecasts, quotes, and code. Corrected prices still use the original issuance cutoff; no model forecast changed.

Reproduction

README.md lists the preparation, training, evaluation, inference, source imports, and grading commands. REPORT.html links all checkpoints, exact probabilities, source hashes, and validation records. Complete timestamped historical injury coverage and historical EPA fitting vintages remain limitations.

2026 Week 6 recommended ranking

Rank	Team	Mean neutral win probability
1	Notre Dame	0.9550
2	Georgia	0.9432
3	Miami	0.9347
4	Indiana	0.9294
5	Alabama	0.9261
6	Utah	0.9064
7	Wake Forest	0.8995
8	Houston	0.8994
9	Oregon State	0.8887
10	Texas	0.8881
11	Iowa	0.8876
12	Ohio State	0.8872
13	BYU	0.8849
14	LSU	0.8819
15	Missouri	0.8751
16	Northwestern	0.8606
17	Texas Tech	0.8566
18	Florida	0.8488
19	UCLA	0.8486
20	South Carolina	0.8454
21	Oklahoma State	0.8404
22	Mississippi State	0.8390
23	USC	0.8370
24	Pittsburgh	0.8349
25	Ole Miss	0.8336

Each team is evaluated against the same complete modeled field. Every feature variant’s FBS and combined FBS/FCS rankings are available in the HTML and CSV. Ranking scores and matchup forecasts answer a predictive question, not earned accomplishments.